journey, they've probably got it right this time. Or so it seems...

What's new?

Some of the best features that Windows 7 offers include Aerosnap for smarter window management and usability enhancements such JumpLists, taskbar enhancements and ubiquitous search. An all new Media Center adds to the appeal of Windows 7 as the new OS of choice for HTPCs. Yet one of the most talked about features of the new OS is the new multi-touch capability. Microsoft's love affair with touch began long ago with surface, the multi-touch, multi-user, projection-based tablet that has applications in the high end entertainment and retail space. But this is the first time multi-touch is being embedded into an operating system that is accessible to the masses.

Windows 7 brings in touch interface capabilities, and is set to change the face of desktops

Touch hardware

The prospect of touch and particularly multi-touch has always evoked a certain thrill for all of us. We've been seeing such technology in science fiction for ages; right from ***Star Trek*** to fancy hand gestures in ***Minority Report***. Microsoft's Surface that debuted in CES 2008 fired up viewers imaginations as to the applications that the table top device can have. Windows 7 has finally made this somewhat of a reality by bringing multi-touch to personal computing.

"Both Surface and Windows had worked collaboratively to bring Surface and applications to the Windows 7 PC experience"
Rajiv Popli, Director, Windows Client, Consumer & Online Business, Microsoft India

With its full multi-touch capability, Windows 7 will perhaps sow the seeds for a whole new set of devices and applications in varied form factors from desktops to different designs in the portability space; from netbooks to tablets.

According to Rajiv Popli, Director, Windows Client, Microsoft, the journey to touch began from an endeavour towards simplicity. "This is the first time we've got multi-touch available to a larger audience. And the form factors we'll be seeing in the touch space will be truly exciting. We've now brought the technology to a level where the adoption will increase due to the kind of applications that can be built on top of it. The ease makes it potentially pervasive. More and more OEMs are building PCs that make use of this technology," he adds. The first of these Windows 7 touch products are already out from the stables of hardware manufacturers such as HP and Dell and if the grapevine is to be believed then the newest entrant will be Acer.

Of Atoms and Ions

Windows 7 being light is Atom friendly. Still the processor is not beefy enough to run fancy graphics. Enter NVIDIA's Ion Platform. We spoke to Igor Stanek, Product Manager for ION / notebooks, EMEAI region from NVIDIA to understand how this works, and enhances the Windows 7 experience. "Our story with Windows 7 is all about CPU and GPU harmonics. The CPU operates on very complicated sequential codes, while the GPU operates on massively parallel operations. Windows 7 uses this untapped power of the GPU, in this case the GeForce 9400M. If you were to encode video on an Atom processor, you would take about 7 hours for a movie. The same on Ion will be done in real time – one and a half hour, thanks to its 16 cores", he said.

The GPU is no longer just for graphics. In Windows 7, the CPU and the GPU create a co-processing environment. What makes this co-processing possible is one of the most significant additions Windows 7 brings – DirectCompute which enables applications in Windows 7 to take advantage of GPU computing to accelerate applications. "Try Loiloscope – the fun video creation application which supports our CUDA architecture." says Igor.

A lot of manufacturers are working with touchscreen devices and the possibilities with the Ion platform with Windows 7 are limitless. The platform features lower power consumption, runs cool and still gives incredible compute power. Perhaps the new generation of imminent full touch tablets have found their perfect engine.

Revolution...really?

While touch sounds exciting, before getting carried away, we must ask ourselves, is touch just a gimmick? Or is there some functionality to it? So far whatever we've seen in the market based on earlier operating systems without multi-touch leaves you with the same nagging doubts. Microsoft's Surface for example, although multi touch, has applications in novelty environments like entertainment kiosks or airport lounges, and is not accessible to the ordinary consumer. The other instances of touch PCs based on Intel's Intel Classmate PC concept are mainly learning aids for kids. Net-tops such as the Asus Eee Top (also earlier based on XP) can't possibly be conceived as something that can be used in day-to-day computing. They're something that can at best be a second PC or a "Kitchen PC" as they are popularly being called; meant primarily for viewing purposes. So in effect they remain some what of a novelty. With multitouch what will change remains to be seen.

Touchy issues

It's great that touch has been incorporated into Windows 7 but it's not really woven into the DNA of the operating